

HABITAT DESTRUCTION

The oceans are vast, and it once seemed that nothing we did could affect them. People thought that the oceans could absorb anything we dumped in them, from raw sewage to nuclear waste, and that any damage caused by our activities would be quickly healed by the richness of oceanic life. But a combination of overfishing, pollution, and coastal development is destroying many oceanic habitats and killing their wildlife. In some parts of the oceans, the damage is so severe that it may be irreversible, because the wildlife that once flourished there has been wiped out.

◀ RED TIDE

A huge quantity of untreated sewage is pumped into the oceans. This can contain dangerous microbes, and may overstimulate the growth of plankton to create a toxic red tide. When the dense cloud of plankton dies, its decay uses up all the oxygen in the water, killing marine life.

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POLLUTING POISONS



OIL

This is regularly dumped at sea by ships, spilled by wrecked oil tankers, or leaked from damaged oil rigs. It smothers beaches, destroys coastal habitats, and poisons marine life. Oiled seabirds, for example, may survive for long enough to be cleaned up, then die from the toxic effects of the oil they have swallowed.



HEAVY METALS

Metals such as mercury and lead are naturally found in the sea, but in tiny amounts. Industrial waste pumped into the ocean can contain much higher concentrations that are poisonous to sea life. Coastal communities have also suffered heavy metal poisoning by eating contaminated seafood.



PESTICIDES

Chemicals used to kill crop pests are just as effective at killing ocean life when rivers carry the pesticides into the sea. Many of these poisons take a long time to decay, and all kinds of sea creatures from fish to polar bears have been found with high levels of poison in their bodies. This may make them ill, and may even kill them.

▶ DEADLY GARBAGE

Vast amounts of waste plastic find their way into the oceans, and stay there since plastic does not decay like other forms of garbage. It traps animals like this seal, which has a plastic packing band cutting deep into its flesh. Giant leatherback turtles have been found with their stomachs full of plastic bags, which they swallow because they look like their main prey, jellyfish. Other animals are killed by discarded fishing nets, which keep trapping marine life for years after they have been thrown overboard.

